

3. Thinking back to my Money Stories from Part Two, am I walking down a financial path that I don't really want to be walking down?

While these are our main questions, there is perhaps even another question beginning to form for you now that we should address before we go any further: Is it even possible to change how our elephant behaves, to equip our rider and to change the path we're naturally inclined or unconsciously biased to walk down?

I'm the sort of person who reads the last page in the book first, so I'm going to give the ending away here: I believe it's not only possible to work with and reharneß our natural instincts, biases, stories and environments so they serve us rather than financially sabotage us; it's essential!

Will some people find this process easier than others? Do some people have a naturally better-behaved elephant? Or in other words, what role does nature play in our ability to apply self-control to our finances? Scientists and researchers are discovering the answers might be found by studying how our brains function.

Let's look at the experiment conducted by Todd Hare, Colin Camerer and Antonio Rangel in 2009, reported in a paper called 'Self-Control in Decision-Making Involves Modulation of the vmPFC Valuation System'. In this study, the researchers monitored the brain patterns of a group of 'self-confessed dieters' while they were shown photos of 50 different foods ranging from healthy foods such as fruit and vegetables through to not-so-healthy foods such as chocolate and chips. The participants were then asked to rate these different foods both on taste and health benefits and the researchers created an index system based on their responses. At the end of the study, the researchers asked the participants to choose food to eat based on the index they had created.

Now I want you to take a guess: do you believe that the 'self-confessed dieters' all chose the healthy option as rated by the index? If you answered 'No, only some did', you'd be right.

Therein lies our critical question when it comes to nature: Did the researchers determine a difference in brain activity between those who exercised self-control by choosing healthy options and those who didn't? They certainly did—the difference was in brain region activity, particularly